I said America was at a crossroads: We had the choice of either continuing on this path or fighting to reclaim the liberties being taken from us. It was a speech, I suppose, that, with variations, I'd given hundreds of times before.

After dinner, five or six people from the audience came up to me and asked if I would join them for a few minutes at their table.

The Coconut Grove by then was almost empty. Except for the waiters, who were noisily clearing off dishes and glassware, everyone was gone except this little group, which I later learned included some of the biggest Republican campaign contributors in California, and I sat down with them.

They asked me if I would be willing to repeat the speech I'd just given for Goldwater on national television if they could raise the money to buy airtime for it.

"Sure," I said, "if you think it would do any good."

If we did it, I suggested that instead of repeating my speech in front of a camera in a television studio, it might be more effective if I spoke to an audience in a setting similar to the one in which they'd heard it. They agreed and within a few days had raised enough money to buy a half hour of time on NBC a week before the election. We taped the speech in a big NBC studio in front of an audience of invited Republicans, simulating the kind of gatherings that I'd been speaking to for years.

A few days before the speech was scheduled to go on the air, I got a telephone call from Barry Goldwater. He sounded uneasy and a little uncomfortable.

Some of his advisors, Barry said, wanted him to use the airtime that had been purchased for my speech to rebroadcast a videotape of a meeting he'd had at Gettysburg with Ike Eisenhower.

He said they were afraid my speech, coming so close to the eve of the election, might backfire on him because of